The SFV9 Bid Path

Six stages every federal pursuit moves through. Go/No-Go is the tipping point: nothing gets written until the critical gaps are answered.

STAGE 1

Research

2–8 weeks · 14 gap questions

Mission, money, people, and a way to buy

Exit criteria: A named office, champion and budget owner; a funding source; a buying path (vehicle, partner or direct buy); and every eligibility gap known.

Must answer: Which office owns the mission this solves? · Who is the champion, and have they said they will push for this? · Who owns the budget (program manager), and have we met them?

TOP BLOCKERS

- No funds identified
- No contract vehicle access
- No signed VAR or channel agreement
- No facility clearance (FCL)

STAGE 2

Capture & Shape

3–12 months · 12 gap questions

Shape the requirement and build the team

Exit criteria: Requirement shaped, competition known, set-aside decision understood, team signed, and past performance in hand.

Must answer: Will it be a set-aside, and do we qualify? · Who is the incumbent, and why would the customer switch? · Do we need a prime? Is the teaming agreement signed, with workshare?

TOP BLOCKERS

- Requirements written around a competitor
- A set-aside you don't qualify for
- Teaming or VAR agreement not signed
- No federal past performance

STAGE 3 · TIPPING POINT

Go/No-Go

1–3 days · 8 gap questions

The tipping point: commit, or walk away

Exit criteria: A written Go or No-Go decision, with the reasons, and proposal resources committed if it is a Go.

Must answer: Is there a named champion who will advocate for us internally? · Is funding confirmed for the fiscal year of award? · Do we have a legal way to be bought: our vehicle, a signed partner, or a direct buy?

TOP BLOCKERS

- No champion
- Funding not confirmed
- No path to buy
- A hard requirement not met (FCL, certification, size)

STAGE 4

Proposal

2–6 weeks · 10 gap questions

Write it compliant, price it to win, submit on time

Exit criteria: A compliant, reviewed proposal submitted before the deadline.

Must answer: When is it due, how is it submitted, and who presses submit? · Is every Section L instruction and Section M factor mapped in a compliance matrix? · Is pricing built in the solicitation's format (line items, labor categories)?

TOP BLOCKERS

- Rejected for non-compliance
- Can't meet the DD254
- Accounting system not ready for cost-type work
- Late submission

STAGE 5

Evaluation & Award

1–6 months · 6 gap questions

Clarifications, discussions and the award decision

Exit criteria: Award decision received, and ready to perform on day one if you won.

Must answer: Who answers clarification questions, and are they reachable? · If the work is classified, is our FCL active, and are cleared staff ready for the DD254?

TOP BLOCKERS

- Missed clarification deadline
- FCL not granted in time
- A protest
- Funding slips

STAGE 6

Closed Won/Lost

First 30 days after award · 8 gap questions

Debrief, kickoff or protest, and the next pursuit

Exit criteria: Debrief done and lessons logged. If won: kicked off, invoicing working and an expansion plan. If lost: the next pursuit named.

Must answer: Did we request a debrief in writing within three days?

TOP BLOCKERS

- Missed the debrief window
- DD254 not flowed down
- Invoicing not set up
- Doing extra work without a contract change